

A turning point

With classification slots now available domestically, India's para sport ecosystem has gained the fillip it needs for **long-term growth.**

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For para athletes, the road to competition does not begin on the track or field, but in a quiet room where a panel of experts decides which classification an athlete belongs to.

Until recently, India's parathletes had little choice but to travel abroad for classification, shutting the door on many who could not afford it. That changed earlier this year when India hosted its first-ever World Para Athletics Grand Prix in New Delhi.

For the first time, dozens of Indian athletes were able to undergo classification at home — a shift that not only saves money and expands opportunity but could also reshape the country's entire para sport system. "Hosting a Grand Prix in India was nothing short of a lifeline," said Manish Rana, Director of Sports Development and Performance with the Paralympic Committee of India (PCI).

Classification is the foundation that determines fairness and eligibility in every para sport. "It is the building unit of the entire Paralympic

ecosystem," Rana explained. "Just imagine an athlete training for two years, believing they belong in one category, only to discover they're in another. Getting classification early helps them train with clarity."

Why it matters

Classifying para athletes is not a simple tick-box exercise but an extensive process overseen by trained international experts. A two-member team can classify only eight or nine athletes in a day, which means slots are scarce. India often had to fight for space at overseas events, typically managing only a handful of slots. Thus many athletes missed their chance entirely.

The financial burden, too, was crushing. "A single trip abroad could cost Rs. 2.5-3 lakh for an athlete, with expenses doubling if an escort is required," said Rana.

The Delhi Grand Prix, however, changed that equation overnight. India secured 61 classification slots out of 120 available — a scale unimaginable until then. "Beyond cost savings, this was about building a culture of access," Rana said. "We even got the IPC to dedicate the first day entirely to Indian athletes."

The event set the tone for the future, with India having already been awarded the rights to host three more Grand Prix events in the next three years. "If we consistently get 50-60 slots each year, we could classify 200 athletes domestically over the Paralympic cycle," he said. "That's a game-changer."

Another crucial outcome of hosting the Grand Prix was the training and certification of a new cadre of National Technical Officers (NTOs), the backbone of para sport competitions.

NTOs ensure rules are followed, classifications are implemented correctly, and events are conducted smoothly. "If you don't have technical officials, classifiers, competition managers — the whole ecosystem suffers. That's why we invested in NTO training. Hosting events here means they all get to see how the system works first-hand," said Rana.

For India, this represents a crucial shift away from dependence on outside expertise. "Earlier, we had to rely on foreign officials or wait for opportunities abroad. Now, we are creating a pool of our own." The pool is now part of a larger ecosystem that is finally taking shape.